

I. Introduction

God is love (1 John 4:7). And nowhere is God's love realized more than in the Catholic Church, where Christ pours out His life through the sacraments (cf. John 19:34). I have come to realize this in my personal journey with faith, as the sacraments have fundamentally transformed my life, and my appreciation for this truth has only deepened by taking this course.

II. The Four Pillars and the Sacraments

1. *The Creed (What We Believe)*

If you're anything like me, you know the ache of chasing after things that never satisfy. Whether it's a relaxing weekend off work, playing our favorite game, or a long-awaited vacation, we are always left wanting more.

I learned this the hard way in my struggle with addiction. At my lowest, no matter how many hits I took, I could never get enough. I would get high, always craving a little more, never able to fill the emptiness I felt. I was looking for something, but I was looking in the wrong place because "only in God will he find the truth and happiness he never stops searching for" (CCC 27).

Luckily, "God never ceases to draw man to himself" (CCC 27).

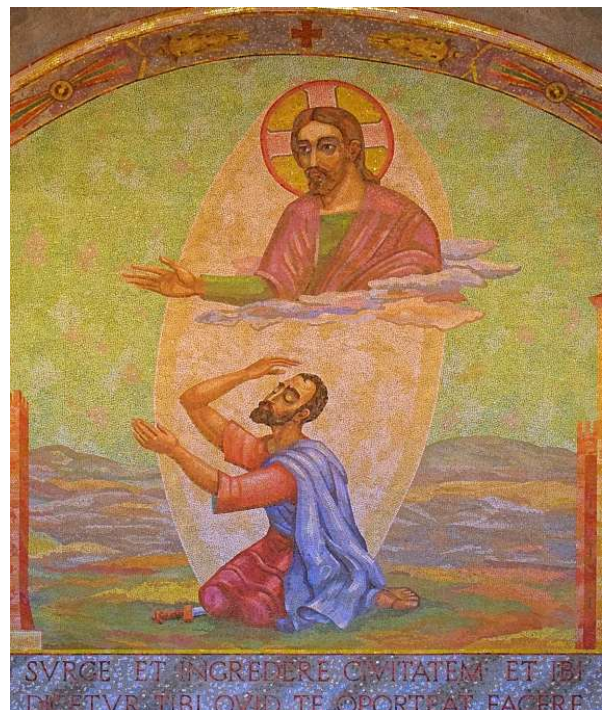
When I bought my first Bible, I read, "I am the way, and the truth, and the life" (John 14:6). In the Gospels, especially in the Sermon on the Mount, I instantly recognized the same voice I'd heard within me for years was Christ himself, calling me home (cf. John 10:27).

Indeed, I realized that "Sacred Scripture is the speech of God as it is put down in writing under the breath of the Holy Spirit" (CCC 81), the same Spirit that was given to me through baptism and confirmation, whom I had long ignored, yet who was continually drawing me into the fullness of faith.

My life completely changed. The hours I used to spend in shameful acts were now spent diligently studying the Word of God. It wasn't just a book I was reading, He was speaking to me through the pages (cf. Hebrews 4:12). It was like nothing I ever experienced before. I fell in love. I realized that "Jesus Christ is the Son of God" (CCC 454).

2. *The Sacraments (How We Celebrate)*

Jesus transformed my life through my encounter with Him in the Bible. Many of the chains that once held me back were broken after spending



time with Him in Sacred Scripture; however, I was still struggling with sexual sin. Then one night, I took another look at the Gospel of John:

Jesus said to them, “I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will never be hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty.” (John 6:35)

I already realized Jesus was the metaphorical bread of life. The hunger and thirst I had previously satiated with idols were satisfied in a way they never had been once I directed those impulses toward Him. But I kept reading on:

“Very truly, I tell you, whoever believes has eternal life. I am the bread of life ... I am the living bread that came down from heaven. Whoever eats of this bread will live forever; and the bread that I will give for the life of the world is my flesh ... Very truly, I tell you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you. Those who eat my flesh and drink my blood have eternal life, and I will raise them up on the last day; for my flesh is true food and my blood is true drink. Those who eat my flesh and drink my blood abide in me, and I in them.” (John 6:47-48,51,53-56)

I read these words over and over, and over again. I felt the utmost urgency to receive the Eucharist at mass that next Sunday. I made it to the Immaculata, and I instantly fell in love with the beauty of the church. Although I had once felt bored in church, I now wished the Liturgy would never end.

Eventually, the time came to receive Holy Communion. And... I didn't feel much. In fact, that week I started to feel more guilt than I had in a long time (cf. CCC 1385, 1 Corinthians 11:27-29). Without knowing it at the time, I realized that “anyone who desires to receive Christ in Eucharistic communion must be in the state of grace” (CCC 1415), which I was not at the time.

I realized I needed to get to the sacrament of reconciliation as soon as possible. When I got to the church, I was shaking in the car, and I almost left without going in. I worried about how bad my penance was going to be for all the evil I had done. But I called to the Holy Spirit and He guided me into the church. I got in line, and I opened up my Bible, hoping to find comfort. The page I flipped to was right in the middle of the Gospel of Luke. I read:

I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who need no repentance. (Luke 15:7)

My trembling hands started to find some rest. I continued reading:

“... ‘I will get up and go to my father, and I will say to him, “Father, I have sinned against heaven and before you; I am no longer worthy to be called your son; treat me like one of your hired hands.”’ So he set off and went to his father. But while he was still far off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion; he ran and put his arms around him and kissed him.” (Luke 15:18-20)

God told me that was going to be my penance, but I doubted whether it was truly Him. Then, it was my turn to go into the confessional.

With a shaky voice, I confessed: “Bless me father, for I have greatly sinned. It has been 12 years since my last confession.”

A soothing voice replied, “Welcome back.”

And so I started listing my sins. Every last one that I could remember. When I heard the words of absolution, the weight of sin I felt on my heart had lifted, and when the priest told me my penance was to read Luke 15, I felt like I was flying. In that confessional, I experienced the love of God in a way I never had before.



Indeed, coming out, I was filled with “peace and serenity of conscience with strong spiritual consolation” having been reconciled with God (CCC 1468) and the Church (CCC 1469), and knowing the eternal punishment of my sins had been remitted (CCC 1470).

3. Life in Christ (How We Live)

Having been reconciled with God and the Church, I found myself radically changed, not just in how I saw the sacraments, but in how I lived my daily life. The more I received the Eucharist, the more I felt a burning desire to “keep the faith and live on it, but also profess it, confidently bear witness to it, and spread it” (CCC 1816). I started sharing the hope I had found with others going through similar struggles that I had gone through, and I wanted to talk about Jesus with anyone who would listen.

At the same time, I had realized that “sexual pleasure is morally disordered when sought for itself, isolated from its procreative and unitive purposes” (CCC 2351) and that “either man governs his passions and finds peace, or he lets himself be dominated by them and becomes unhappy” (CCC 2339).

I was feeling strong convictions to embrace chastity, which ultimately led to my 6-year-long relationship ending. Losing this relationship was one of the hardest crosses I have had to bear, but “there is no holiness without renunciation and spiritual battle” (CCC 2015).



I am reminded that discipleship means taking up my cross daily and following Christ (cf. Luke 9:23). It has not always been easy, but I know that “God is the source of all our merits” (CCC 2008), and “charity, the form of all the virtues, binds everything together in perfect harmony” (CCC 1844). Through the grace of the sacraments and the support of the Church, I strive to love as Christ loved (cf. John 15:12), trusting that He is making me new (cf. 2 Corinthians 5:17).

4. *Christian Prayer (How We Pray)*

Despite the struggles, the very source of strength, peace, and satisfaction I longed for was found not just in new habits or discipline, but in the body and blood of Jesus Christ. It was in the Eucharist that I encountered Him most intimately: I was drawn into communion with His very life, and this encounter did not end at the altar. It overflowed into my daily life, especially into my prayer. While the Eucharist itself “contains and expresses all forms of prayer” (CCC 2643), receiving it transformed my desire and capacity to pray into a daily longing. And through daily prayer, I found myself truly anchored in Christ.

Amen, “Prayer is the life of the new heart. It ought to animate us at every moment” (CCC 2697, cf. 1 Thessalonians 5:17).

There is nothing that keeps me rooted in God’s love more than regular prayer, especially singing the Liturgy of the Hours, meditating with the Rosary, or spending time in Eucharistic adoration. These “wells where Christ awaits us to give us the Spirit” (CCC 2560) have become for me a greater source of joy and fulfillment than anything the world ever offered.

In the Liturgy of the Hours, I join “the very prayer which Christ himself together with his Body addresses to the Father” (CCC 1174). The Rosary, with its meditations on the mysteries of Christ’s life, helps me remain close to Mary and to Christ himself (cf. CCC 2678). And in Eucharistic adoration, I acknowledge that I am “a creature before his Creator” (CCC 2628).

In class, praying with icons was a new experience that deepened my sense of God’s presence, and it motivated me to incorporate them into my personal prayer at home.

“Whether prayer is expressed in words or gestures, it is the whole man who prays. But in naming the source of prayer, Scripture speaks sometimes of the soul or the spirit, but most often of the heart” (CCC 2562).



III. Conclusion

Heavenly Father,

Thank You for drawing me out of darkness and into the light of Your Son through the gifts of the Word, the sacraments, the life of charity, and prayer. Thank You for the gift of this Catechism class, which has deepened my faith and has opened the door to many more opportunities to glorify you.

Help me to remain faithful, to hope in Your goodness, and to find my purpose in loving and serving You. May my life be a living testimony to the fullness and truth found in You.

Through our Lord Jesus Christ, Your Son, who lives and reigns with You in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, forever and ever.

Amen.